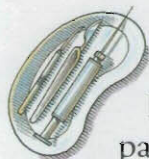


HOSPITALS



ANCIENT ROME HAD special places where sick people could receive medical treatment – the world's earliest hospitals. Today, hospitals have more responsibilities: patient care, health education, and medical research.

Whether general or specialist, most hospitals have wards for in-patients, clinics for out-patients, operating theatres for surgery, and pharmacies for dispensing drugs. Trained staff, such as doctors and nurses, care for patients using complex equipment, while non-medical staff, such as cooks, porters, cleaners, and engineers, are crucial in making the hospital function. In some poorer countries, there may be only one hospital for every million people.

Specialist hospitals

Some specialist hospitals focus on groups of patients, such as women or children. Others concentrate on groups of diseases, such as eye problems, psychiatric disorders, or neurological (nerve-and-brain) diseases. Teaching hospitals train nurses, doctors, and other medical staff.

Children's hospital

Hospitals specializing in the care of sick children use scaled-down equipment, such as surgical instruments, bandages, beds, and chairs. Wards are bright and cheerful for the small patients, and there are toys and games. Parents are able to stay in nearby hospital rooms.



Child's teddy



Flying eye clinic, China

Eye clinics

Ophthalmology – the branch of medicine concerned with eye and sight problems – requires exceptionally detailed and precise equipment, and specialist facilities for patients who may be temporarily unable to see. Some large countries with remote regions, such as China or Australia, can provide these facilities in a mobile form – usually a small plane.

Staff

Doctors usually work in different hospital departments for several years,

to gain general training, before choosing a speciality. Nursing staff may also specialize, for example, in paediatrics (children), psychiatry, or intensive care. A hospital's staff usually includes radio-graphers, laboratory technicians, physio-therapists, and anaesthetists.

Nurses

Nurses attend to patients' comfort and daily needs, such as feeding and washing. They also carry out medical tasks, such as taking and recording pulse rate and body temperature, and giving medications.

General nurse

Equipment

Modern equipment – especially that modified to be mobile – is crucial in hospitals. In an emergency, some of the most useful pieces include breathing apparatus (face masks or tubing), long syringes to administer fast-acting drugs, such as heart stimulants, and fluid products for intravenous infusions (drips).



Emergency trolley

Stethoscope



Oxygen cylinder and trolley

General hospital

A general hospital provides medical facilities for a large area. Its wards cater for patients with common health problems. More complex cases are referred to a specialist hospital. General hospitals also arrange community services, such as visits by nurses.



Chart

Hospital beds in a ward

Wards

In-patients usually stay in dormitory-type wards. They are separated into medical and surgical groups of children, men, women, and the elderly. Patients with infectious diseases usually stay in isolation rooms.



Ambulance, New York, USA

Accident and emergency

The A&E department receives medical emergencies, such as accident or heart-attack victims. The patient's problem is identified and stabilized, after which he or she may be sent home, or transferred to a suitable general ward.



Premature baby in incubator

Neo-natal intensive care unit

Intensive care unit

In intensive care, expert staff attend gravely ill patients round the clock. Electronic equipment continually monitors their vital processes, such as heartbeat and breathing.



Waiting room

Out-patients

Out-patients attend the hospital to undergo screening tests or have minor surgery. They do not stay overnight.

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